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MCH3063

Assessment Two

Topic 8: Ethics and politics are revolutionising consumer attitudes and practice. Critically evaluate this claim in relation to one of the following and one or more case study examples:

Ethical consumerism vs global corporations Sustainability vs accessibility

Activism vs 'X-washing' (i.e. sports-washing/ green-washing/rainbow-washing etc.)

Total Word Count: 2770

I hereby certify that this submission is wholly my own work, and that all quotations and ideas from primary or secondary sources have been acknowledged. I have read the section on Plagiarism in the Programme Handbook and understand that plagiarism and other unacknowledged debts will be penalised and may lead to failure in the whole examination or degree.

Introduction

Marxist theoretical frameworks critically analyse the complex interplay between consumer ethics and corporate practices. I will attempt to reveal the intricate relationship between consumer consciousness, corporate responses and the overall structure of capitalism that influences these dynamics.

At the heart of ethical consumerism is the growing consumer awareness of and concern for the ethical implications of their purchasing choices. Large corporations frequently perpetuate or disregard sociopolitical injustice, environmental degradation, and labour exploitation, as they pursue profit maximisation. This shift towards ethical considerations can be interpreted as a reaction to these worldwide socioeconomic problems. Because the capitalist system has historically placed profit above moral considerations, ethical consumerism may be perceived as a critique or opposition to that system. From my research, it appears that ethical consumerism opposes the commodification that is intrinsic to capitalism; however, it frequently reinforces it unintentionally, as Gunderson's article refutes this view. The investigation of consumer-business relations is predicated on this paradox. For this investigation, Marxist analysis offers a robust framework. Understanding the fetishization of consumer commodities, the commodification of goods, and the function of consumer consciousness within the capitalist economy are all facilitated by this resource(Gunderson,2014).

Marx argued that commodities in the capitalist system mask the labour and moral considerations behind their production - a process he called 'commodity fetishism'. Ethical consumerism can be seen as an attempt to 'de-commoditise' as consumers seek to reveal the reality of production and respond to it (Marx, 1867). However, this 'de-commodification' is complex and often incomplete, as the market logic of capitalism tends to incorporate ethical issues into new forms of commodification. Decommodification theories claim

that alternative markets can lead to a more honest and less secretive relationship with food production, which in turn strengthens civil society. Gunderson utilises Marxist theories of political economy and environmental sociology to assert three overarching claims: (1) capitalism possesses an inherent tendency to cause ecological and social harm; (2) commodities labelled as "ethical" from alternative markets do not fundamentally mitigate the widespread and extensive consequences of (1); and (3) due to the presence of (1) and (2), commodities labelled as "moral" from alternative markets do not fundamentally offset the universal and extensive impact of (1). Both (1) and (2), (3) ethical consumerism does not venerate the commodity form, but instead functions as an additional level of commodity fetishism, concealing the negative effects of capitalism and the commodity form itself by persuading society that the damages caused by capitalism can be rectified(Gunderson,2014). In my view, the implementation of conventional, extensive political measures is necessary to accomplish the goal of "de-worship".

In order to analyse these elements, this paper adopts an approach that combines semiotic and discourse analysis. Through semiotic analysis, I have found that it is possible to examine how goods and corporate behaviour are represented and symbolised in the media and advertising. This approach reveals the signs and symbols that are used to convey ethical messages or mask unethical practices. Discourse analysis complements these analyses by examining the language and narratives used by businesses and consumers to articulate ethical issues. More than that, this methodological convergence provides a comprehensive toolset for dissecting the complex ways in which moral consumerism is constructed, disseminated and contested within the capitalist framework. Overall, the theoretical underpinnings of Marxism, based on the theories described in my analyses and those provided by Clark's article, provide a critical lens through which to view the phenomenon of moral

consumerism. It has been proven since these early contacts that consumption behaviours are rarely those of rational, independent, self-identified consumers, and that so-called ethical consumption practices are rarely separated from organisations and their political actions. As a result, some scholars have increasingly turned their focus away from consumer identity and knowledge and towards consuming habits, social networks, physical infrastructures, and various organisations. This shift in emphasis has ramifications for both the field of political consumption and geography's relationship to it. Political consumption studies have dug into the political behaviour of consumer choice in capitalist cultures, proposing that purchase can be a form of political resistance. However, in a system that ultimately commodifies dissent, this resistance is riddled with contradictions(Clarke, 2008).

Moral Consumerism in the Age of the Global Corporation

The term "ethical consumerism" implies a shift in consumer behaviour whereby purchasing decisions are influenced not only by price and quality, but also by moral, ethical and environmental factors. According to Carrington, this shift is a challenge to traditional capitalist practices in which businesses are primarily concerned with maximising profits, often at the expense of ethical considerations. Despite ethical intentions, ethically conscious consumers rarely buy ethical products. This gap between intention and behaviour is important to both researchers and industry, but is little understood. Based on my research, I have found that the fast fashion industry is characterised by fast production cycles, low product costs and has been criticised for exploiting labour and damaging the environment. Increasing consumer awareness and demand for ethical production is forcing these companies to re-evaluate their business models and practices(Carrington et al.,2010).

However, as Gunderson points out, multinational corporations' responses to ethical consumerism are often superficial adjustments rather than

fundamental changes in business behaviour(Gunderson,2014). Using this so-called adjustment to achieve their commercial ends, this adjustment may take the form of 'greenwashing', whereby companies make unsubstantiated claims that their products are environmentally friendly or ethical, thereby concealing the exploitative behaviour behind them. And in this context, Marx's concept of "commodity fetishism" is particularly important here. This concept suggests that in the capitalist market the social relations and labour conditions behind the production of commodities are blurred and that the value of a commodity depends on its exchange value rather than its use value or the moral implications of its production (Marx, 1867). While striving to minimise the worth of goods and services, moral consumerism frequently encounters the paradoxical situation where moral decision-making within the capitalist market may unintentionally sustain the very system it opposes.

Consumer decision-making is profoundly impacted by TNCs. Influencing consumer perceptions and decisions significantly are the marketing strategies and supply chain management of TNCs. As per my investigation, corporations have the ability to sway consumer perceptions of what qualifies as a "ethical" product by employing branding and targeted advertising strategies; this frequently deflects focus away from systemic concerns, including labour and production practices. It is not merely an economic activity, but rather a defining characteristic and structuring principle of contemporary society, according to Baudrillard's research. Consumption, he emphasises, is a symbolic social act in addition to the fulfilment of material necessities. Commodities undergo a metamorphosis wherein they acquire symbolic significance and status, in addition to their physical nature, carrying diverse social and cultural connotations. Baudrillard explores the 'myths' and structures of the consumer society, including analyses of concepts of well-being, lifestyles, and social relations in modern societies. He argues that consumer culture creates the illusion that personal happiness and social progress can be achieved through

consumption, but that this actually masks social inequality and cultural hollowing out. This manipulation of consumer perceptions is consistent with Marx's theory of ideology, in which the ruling class propagates dominant ideas and values in order to maintain its economic and political power. The interplay between consumer agency and corporate influence raises key questions about the effectiveness of ethical consumerism as a form of resistance to the capitalist system. Drawing on my research on the concept of 'radical consumption', i.e. consumer behaviour as a form of social and political protest, Littler explores how political positions and social values are expressed through the choice to buy particular products or support particular brands, and how consumerism interacts with personal identity, social class and environmental persistence (Littler, 2009). While consumers can make choices that appear to contradict the unethical behaviour of multinational corporations, the extent to which these choices can bring about systemic change remains controversial. This suggests that structural changes are needed in the way production and consumption are conceptualised and practised within capitalism. While ethical consumerism marks a significant shift in consumer awareness and behaviour, its implications for global business and the wider capitalist system are complex and multifaceted. However, when viewed through a Marxist lens, the inherent contradictions and limitations of ethical consumerism highlight the challenge of reconciling moral intentions with capitalist market dynamics.

Corporate Responses to Ethical Consumerism

How transnational corporations have responded to the rise of ethical consumerism, a complex interaction of adaptation, resistance, and sometimes manipulation, can be understood through the lens of the Marxist critique of the capitalist system. The focus of my analysis is that these corporations, ostensibly aligned with ethical values, often perpetuate the very capitalist ideologies and practices that ethical consumerism seeks to challenge.

Transnational corporations have not remained passive in the face of the ethical consumerism movement. Many have launched 'ethical' product ranges, corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives and marketing campaigns to emphasise their commitment to social and environmental causes. Lyon and Maxwell have developed an economic model of a phenomenon known as 'greenwashing', whereby a company creates misinformation about its environmental practices or products (Lyon & Maxwell, 2011). My research suggests that "greenwashing" is not only a public relations tactic, but also a manifestation of entrenched capitalism, in which companies strategically disclose environmental information, and activists can audit and penalise companies that disclose the positive, rather than the negative, aspects of their environmental profile. In this context, the ethical attributes of products become another aspect of competition and market differentiation rather than a genuine commitment to ethical practice.

The role of CSR in business strategy is particularly evident. CSR initiatives are often touted as evidence of a company's commitment to ethical practices. However, in my understanding, as Banerjee critically analyses contemporary discourses of CSR and related discourses of sustainable development and corporate citizenship (Banerjee, 2008). He argues that despite their emancipatory rhetoric, discourses of corporate citizenship, social responsibility and sustainability are defined by narrow business interests and undermine the interests of external stakeholders. Such a line of thinking offers an alternative view of the discourses of corporate citizenship, CSR and sustainability as ideological movements aimed at legitimising and consolidating the power of large corporations. In his article, Klein exposes the global production practices of a number of large branded corporations, including the use of cheap labour in developing countries and production in countries with lower environmental standards (Klein, 2009). The authors also question the popular notion of organisational 'stakeholders'. These initiatives

can be seen as strategic responses to external pressures aimed at maintaining legitimacy and market position rather than achieving real social or environmental change. This is consistent with Marxist theories of capitalism, whereby the primary objective of the capitalist firm remains profit maximisation and all other considerations are secondary and often instrumental.

From a Marxist perspective, the corporate response to ethical consumerism is complex. Bakan's argument is that the legal and cultural status of modern business aims to profit shareholders at the expense of morality, social welfare and environmental protection. The challenges to ethical consumerism therefore relate to the broader issues of global capitalism rather than to the behaviour of individual enterprises(Bakan,2012).

Consumer agency and market forces in ethical consumerism

The role of consumer agency in ethical consumerism in the context of market forces and capitalist ideology. Consumer agency in ethical consumerism is often hailed as a powerful force for change. Decisions to buy or boycott certain products based on ethical considerations represent a form of consumer activism that challenges corporations and influences market trends. In my reading, however, this activism is not absolute and is often limited by the nature of capitalist market structures. Consumer choices are not made in a vacuum, but are heavily influenced by advertising, branding and market offerings. Consumer culture is not just about buying and selling goods; it also profoundly affects individual identities, social relations and cultural practices. Consumers are often faced with limited ethical choices and their choices are influenced by a combination of economic, social and cultural factors. How power relations in consumer culture influence and shape consumer choices and preferences through marketing and advertising. Slater analyses how advertising and marketing strategies construct and communicate particular lifestyles and values, and the impact of these strategies on individuals and

society. (Slater, 1997)

In addition, the role of consumers in driving ethical change is highly debated. While consumers' individual choices can put pressure on businesses, the systemic nature of issues such as labour exploitation and environmental degradation require consumers to change more than just their consumption behaviour. From a civic perspective, I argue that focusing on individual consumer responsibility may divert attention from the need for systemic change, effectively absolving corporations and governments of responsibility for addressing these issues. Although consumerism has largely shaped the lifestyles and values of modern society, more and more people are becoming dissatisfied with this way of life. She argues that this dissatisfaction is not rooted solely in environmental issues or economic inequality, but in a deeper reflection on the "good life". Soper (2007).

The role of consumers in driving ethical change is also highly contested. While consumers' individual choices can put pressure on businesses, the systemic nature of issues such as labour exploitation and environmental degradation requires consumers to change more than just their consumption behaviour. From a civic perspective, I argue that focusing on the responsibility of individual consumers may divert attention from the need for systemic change, effectively absolving businesses and governments of responsibility for addressing these issues. Although consumerism has largely shaped the lifestyles and values of modern society, more and more people are becoming dissatisfied with this way of life. She argues that this dissatisfaction does not stem solely from environmental problems or economic inequality, but rather a deeper reflection on the "good life" (Soper, 2007). The influence of market forces on ethical consumerism is also important. Capitalist markets are driven by competition, profit maximisation and consumer demand. In this system, ethical considerations often become secondary to economic imperatives. As the article "The Consumer Society: Myths and Structures" points out, in

consumer societies, the symbolic value of goods (including their moral attributes) is often used to gain market advantage. This can lead to ethical consumerism being co-opted by the market, with ethics being just another aspect of product differentiation rather than a driver of real change. Baudrillard (1998)

The global nature of capitalist markets exacerbates this problem. The complexity of global supply chain networks and differences in national standards make it difficult for consumers to determine the moral impact of their purchasing behavior. As Harvey pointed out, an important feature of contemporary capitalism is this global complexity, as the choices of local consumers may have unpredictable impacts on a global scale. In order to better serve the interests of capitalism, neoliberalism emerged as a political economic method aimed at reconstructing power relations (Harvey, 2007). He believes that the goal of neoliberalism is to reduce government intervention in the economy, promote market freedom and privatization, while weakening the social security and rights of workers.

The study points out that the interaction between consumer choice, corporate strategy, and systemic market forces highlights the complexity of achieving true moral change within the current capitalist framework. Ritzer's article argues that this consumption model will lead to the loss of local characteristics and the homogenization of consumer culture, especially how they become symbols of global culture and lifestyle, affecting consumption habits in different regions and cultures (Ritzer, 2010).

Conclusion.

Overall, applying the Marxist theoretical framework to study moral consumerism in the international business field reveals a complex picture full of contradictions and difficulties. According to analysis, consumer choices are

often constrained by capitalist market structures and forces, which determine the effectiveness of moral consumerism as a tool of change, and sometimes limit this effectiveness. Therefore, I believe that due to the global nature of market forces and capitalist systems, the impact of moral consumerism has become increasingly complex. In this situation, we need to reassess the focus on individual consumer responsibility and emphasize the importance of collective action and systemic reform.

As a solution, there is a need for governments to develop stronger policy and regulatory frameworks that provide for ethical business behaviour and transparency. Such regulations would reduce reliance on consumer discernment, lower the risk of "greenwashing" and promote ethical consumption. Second, the role of collective action and social movements in driving systemic change is indispensable. These movements can pressure governments and businesses to take responsibility and promote a more ethical culture. Capitalism and consumption patterns may need to be reconceptualised. As scholars such as Gibson have argued, economic models that prioritise social and environmental well-being over profit can provide a more ethical and sustainable future. There is a need for a radical change in social values and economic structures that rejects the consumerist model of contemporary capitalism(Gibson,2006).

References:

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Action plan to strengthen summative assessment based on mid-term formative feedback

Objective:

To refine and improve the summative assessment paper "Moral Consumerism and the Global Corporation: a Marxist Perspective" based on feedback from the interim formative assessment.

Action Plan:

Improve the clarity and consistency of analyses:

Action: Review the essay to ensure that each paragraph presents a clear and coherent argument directly related to the thesis statement.

METHODOLOGY: Use a detailed outline to track the flow of arguments and ensure that each argument contributes to the overall thesis statement.

Clarify methods and methodology:

Action: Clearly state the methods and approaches used in the essay, focusing on semiotics and discourse analysis.

METHODOLOGY: Briefly describe these methods in the introduction and ensure that the analysis section reflects these methods.

Integrate a strong theoretical framework (Marxism):

Action: Use Marxist theory to deepen the analysis, focussing on concepts such as commodity fetishism, consumerism in capitalist societies and the class struggle inherent in consumer choices.

Method: Review key Marxist texts and secondary sources to enhance understanding and application of Marxist theory within the texts.

Resources: "Marx's Capital," Jean Baudrillard's "The Consumer Society," and

J.K. Gibson Graham's "Postcapitalist Politics.

Avoid repetition:

ACTION: Review the essay carefully and remove redundant arguments or examples.

Method: Identify and delete or merge overlapping sections with a critical eye.

Seek peer review to get more perspectives on content redundancy.

Incorporate additional scholarly resources:

Action: Based on feedback, include additional scholarly sources with important insights into ethical consumerism and Marxism.

Method: Conduct a comprehensive literature review to locate relevant and up-to-date scholarly articles. Pay particular attention to works that critique or extend Marxist theory in the context of modern consumerism.

Strengthen conclusions:

Action: Write a stronger conclusion that not only synthesises the main ideas of the article but also provides critical insights into the future trajectory of moral consumerism in capitalism.

Method: Reflect on the key findings and theories discussed in the article and suggest potential future research directions or practical implications.

Proofreading and final review:

Action: Undertake thorough proofreading and editing to ensure the article is free of grammatical errors and logically clear.

Methods: Final review using a grammar checking tool and seeking feedback from fellow students or tutors.

Expected Outcome:

Following the implementation of this action plan, it is expected that the essay will be more coherent, theoretically sound, methodologically sound and aligned

with the feedback from the formative assessment. This will improve the overall quality of the summative assessment, demonstrating a deeper understanding and critical analysis of ethical consumerism in the context of global capitalism.